

BEHAVIORAL SCIENCE USING PSYCHOMETRY



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ANALYSIS OF CONFLICT MANAGEMENT STYLE IN AN INFORMATION
TECHNOLOGY ORGANIZATION

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Abstract

This Conflict-Management Style Survey has been designed to understand of an Information Technology Industry Employees characteristic approach, or style, in managing conflict.

In this dissertation, a sample of 63 randomly chosen people from an information technology company in Bangalore are given 'Understand Your Own Conflict Management Style' questionnaire to understand their conflict management style. The results are analyzed and conclusions are drawn based on the occupation, age, years of experience and position.

Introduction

For any organization to be effective and efficient in achieving its goals, the people in the organization need to have a shared vision of what they are striving to achieve, as well as clear objectives for each team / department and individual. You also need ways of recognizing and resolving conflict amongst people, so that conflict does not become so serious that co-operation is impossible. All members of any organization need to have ways of keeping conflict to a minimum - and of solving problems caused by conflict, before conflict becomes a major obstacle to your work. This could happen to any organization, whether it is an NGO, a CBO, a political party, a business or a government.

Conflict management is the process of planning to avoid conflict where possible and organizing to resolve conflict where it does happen, as rapidly and smoothly as possible.

"Competition" usually brings out the best in people, as they strive to be top in their field, whether in sport, community affairs, politics or work. In fact, fair and friendly competition often leads to new sporting achievements, scientific inventions or outstanding effort in solving a community problem.

When competition becomes unfriendly or bitter, though, conflict can begin - and this can bring out the worst in people.

Causes or sources of organizational conflict can be many and varied. The most common causes are the following:

- Scarcity of resources (finance, equipment, facilities, etc)
- Different attitudes, values or perceptions
- Disagreements about needs, goals, priorities and interests
- Poor communication
- Poor or inadequate organizational structure
- Lack of teamwork
- Lack of clarity in roles and responsibilities

Conflict between individuals

People have differing styles of communication, ambitions, political or religious views and different cultural backgrounds. In our diverse society, the possibility of these differences leading to conflict between individuals is always there, and we must be alert to preventing and resolving situations where conflict arises.

Conflict between groups of people

Whenever people form groups, they tend to emphasize the things that make their group "better than" or "different from" other groups. This happens in the fields of sport, culture, religion and the workplace and can sometimes change from healthy competition to destructive conflict.

Conflict within a group of people

Even within one organization or team, conflict can arise from the individual differences or ambitions mentioned earlier; or from rivalry between sub-groups or factions. All leaders and members of the organization need to be alert to group dynamics that can spill over into conflict.

Analysis statement

An organization is made of people, and they come first in the organization. There is no organization without people, be it a business of information technology, mechanical, medical, textiles, or anything and everything. Managing the people is critical to the success of the organization. Based on the conflict resolving styles of individuals, we can handle them successfully for the organizational growth.

This project aims at understanding the conflict resolving styles of people for an information technology company.

Methodology

To find out the right mix of personality types for a successful organization, around 70 employees from a successful information organization are given 'Understand Your Own Conflict Management Style' questionnaire for scoring. The results are analyzed and the conclusion is drawn to understand the people conflict management style

Organization selection¹

A successful organization is chosen where the author of this dissertation works. The organization is situated in Bangalore which into Information Technology business focusing on online media business. The organization has around two thousand employees mostly with background of engineering major from top schools in India. There are also few people with business major from top B-Schools.

In general, the organization recruits the people with good talent from the academics and the previous employment track record. The organization has been very successful in the business space it is in.

Sample selection

The selection is mostly random and there is no preference or bias. Since the organization is into information technology, people belonged to engineering or technical groups. Each individual has at least a degree with a major in Computer science or web technologies.

Around 70 people were given the printed questionnaire to score and return in day's time or as soon as possible.

Data collect mechanism

Data is collected using printed questionnaire. The questionnaire given in APPENDIX A is used. While giving the questionnaire, the person was given oral introduction on

¹ The name and details of the organization is not disclosed to protect privacy of the people who took the personality test

- Why the data is collected?
- How to answer the questionnaire?
- How the data will be used?

Also, it was assured that the personal data (name, age, gender, experience, occupation) will be kept anonymous and will not be produced in the report.

Participation

The questionnaire was given to 70 people, and 63 responded with the full scoring. The participants took close to a day to return back the results.

Scoring method:

We provided 30 questions with an option of 'A' or 'B'. Based on the answer, we prepared a below tabulation to calculate the scores for each section. Questionnaires are provided in the Appendix A.

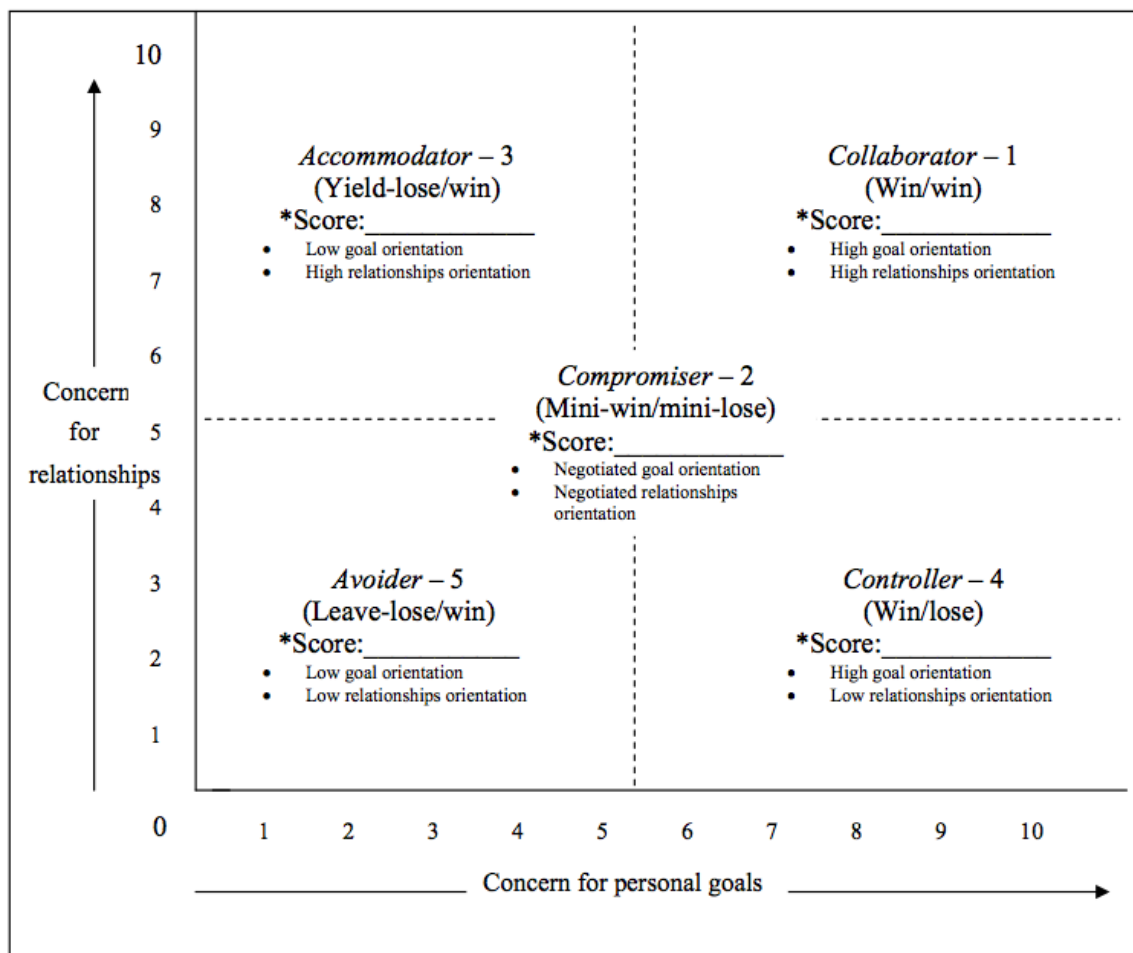
Circled the items below that are marked against each item of the questionnaire by the users.

N	Competin	Collaboratin	Compromisin	Avoidin	Accommodatin
o	g	g	g	g	g
1	B	--	--	A	--
2	--	--	--	B	A
3	--	A	--	B	--
4	B	--	A	--	--
5	--	--	--	A	B
6	A	--	--	--	B
7	--	--	A	B	--

8	B	--	A	--	--
9	A	--	--	B	--
10	--	B	A	--	--
11	--	--	--	A	B
12	A	--	--	B	--
13	A	--	--	--	B
14	--	--	B	--	A
15	--	A	B	--	--
16	--	A	--	B	--
17	--	--	A	--	B
18	--	B	A	--	--
19	A	B	--	--	--
20	--	--	B	--	A
21	--	A	--	--	B
22	--	B	--	--	A
23	A	--	B	--	--
24	--	--	B	A	--
25	--	B	--	--	A
26	B	--	--	--	A
27	B	A	--	--	--
28	A	B	--	--	--
29	--	--	B	A	--
30	--	A	--	B	--
T					

Analysis

Conflict resolving styles are categorized as below with respect to an individual.



Competing or Controlling:

Competing/Controlling is assertive and uncooperative – an individual pursues his or her own concerns at the other person's expense. This is a power-oriented mode, in which one uses whatever power seems appropriate to win one's own position – one's ability to argue, one's rank, economic sanctions. Competing might mean "standing up for your rights," defending a position, which you believe, is correct, or simply trying to win.

Accommodating:

Accommodating is unassertive and cooperative – the opposite of competing. When accommodating, an individual neglects his or her own concerns to satisfy the concerns of the other person; there is an element of self-sacrifice in this mode. Accommodating might take the form of selfless generosity or charity, obeying another person's order when one would prefer not to, or yielding to another's point of view.

Avoiding:

Avoiding is unassertive and uncooperative – the individual does not immediately pursue his own concerns or those of the other person. He or she does not address the conflict. Avoiding might take the form of diplomatically sidestepping an issue, postponing an issue until a better time, or simply withdrawing from a threatening situation.

Collaborating:

Collaborating is both assertive and cooperative – the opposite of avoiding. Collaborating involves an attempt to work with the other person to find some solution, which fully satisfies the concerns of both persons. It means digging into an issue to identify the underlying concerns of the two individuals and to find an alternative, which meets both sets of concerns. Collaborating between two persons might take the form of exploring a disagreement to learn from each other's insights, concluding to resolve some condition which would otherwise have them competing for resources, or confronting and trying to find a creative solution to an interpersonal problem.

Compromising:

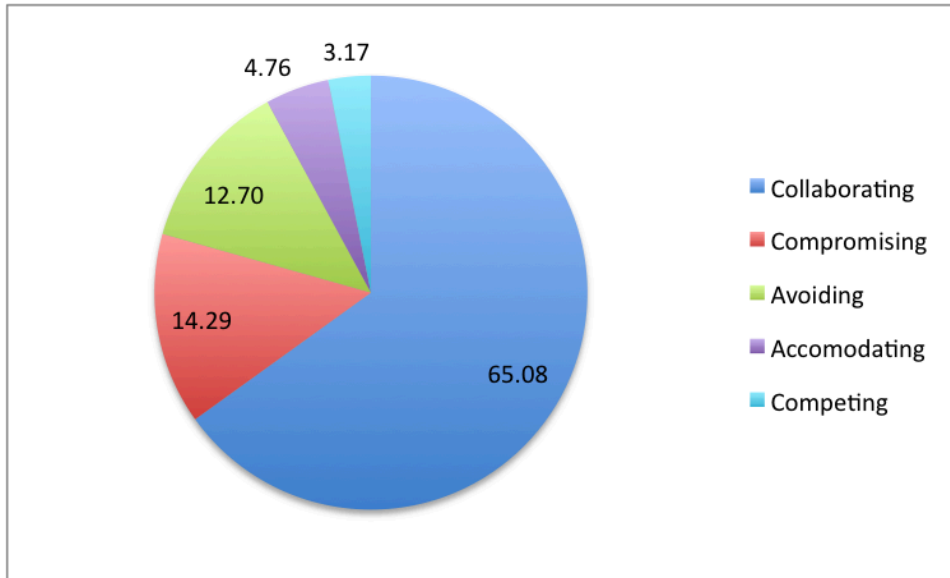
Compromising is intermediate in both assertiveness and cooperativeness. The object is to find some expedient, mutually acceptable solution, which partially satisfies both parties. It falls on a middle ground between competing and accommodating. Compromising gives up more than competing but less than accommodating. Likewise, it addresses an issue more directly than avoiding, but doesn't explore it in as much depth as collaborating. Compromising might mean splitting the difference, exchanging concessions, or seeking a quick middle-ground position.

Analysis with actual data

1. First choice while dealing the conflict management

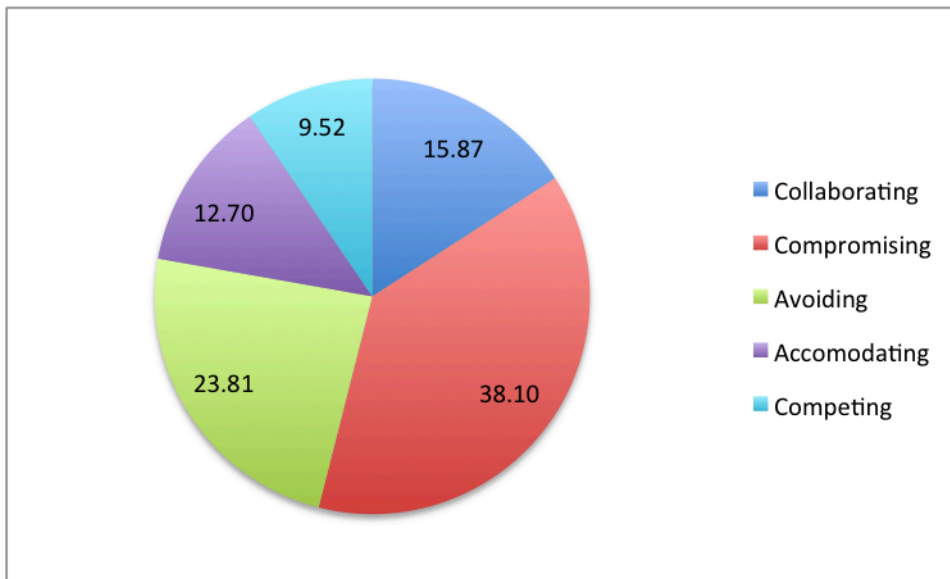
As the graph shows below, majority of people surveyed have collaborating as the primary conflict management style. It can be inferred that for an

organization or group to be successful majority of its people must have collaboration as the primary style for managing conflicts.



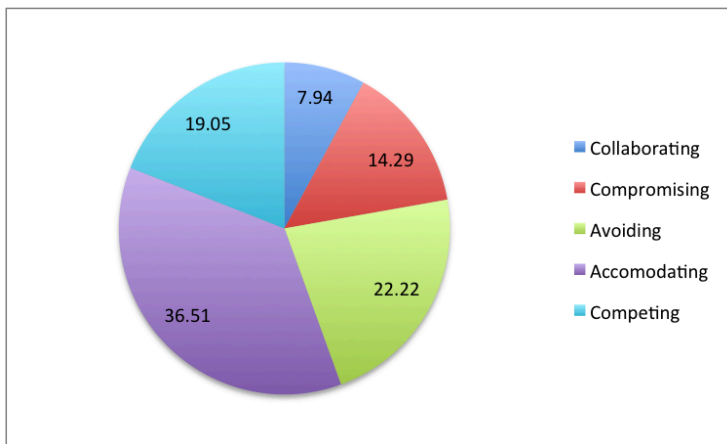
2. Second choice while dealing the conflict management

Compromising is not recommended style for managing the conflict. Even then as per the survey, most of the participants seems to have compromising as the second choice for dealing with conflicts. This is not a good sign. But, since most of them have collaborating a primary style, this can be tolerable.

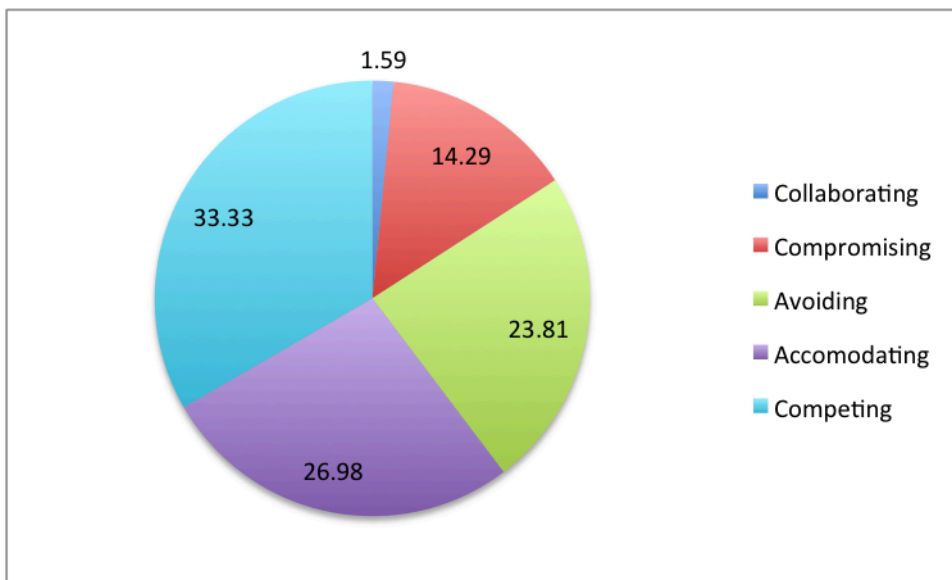


3. Third choice while dealing the conflict management

Accommodating is the good style after collaboration to deal with conflicts. As per the statistics below, the third preferred style for managing conflicts is accommodating which is good sign for an organization.



4. Fourth choice while dealing the conflict management

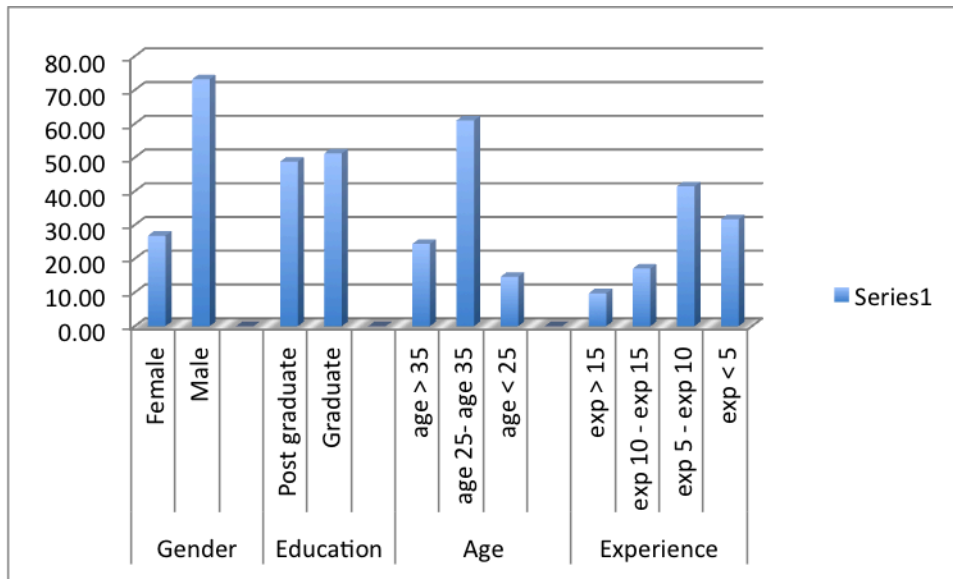


Analysis of conflict management styles

Analysis with the all the people who considered one of the conflicts resolving style as their first option.

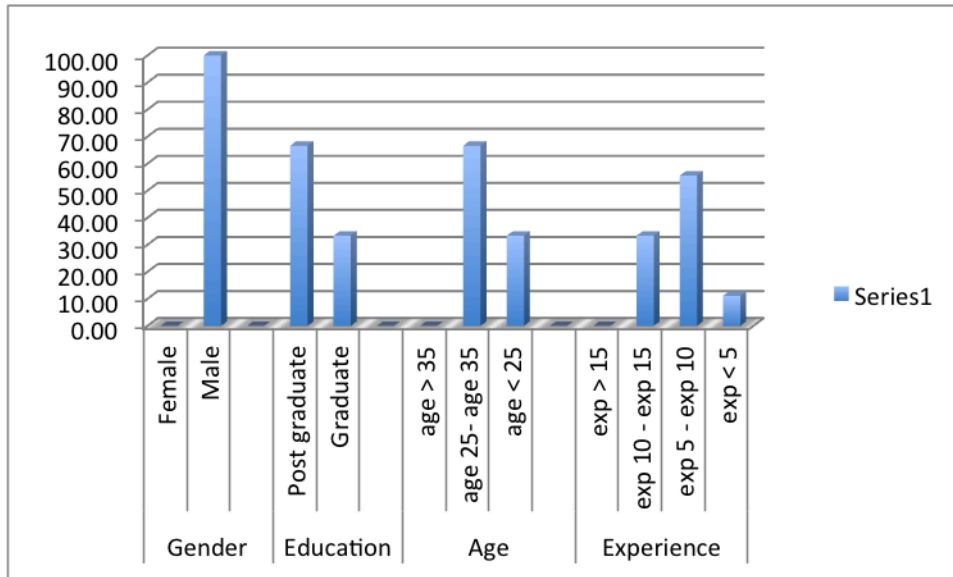
Collaborating:

Dimension	Collaborating	# of People
Gender	Female	11
	Male	30
Education	Post graduate	20
	Graduate	21
Age	age > 35	10
	age 25- age 35	25
	age < 25	6
Experience	exp > 15	4
	exp 10 - exp 15	7
	exp 5 - exp 10	17
	exp < 5	13



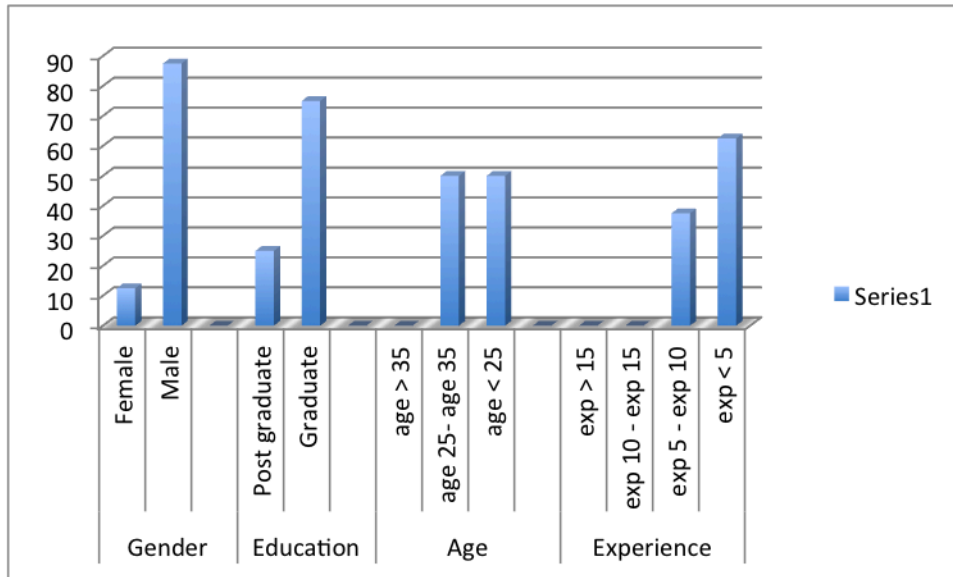
Compromising:

Dimension	Collaborating	# of People
Gender	Female	11
	Male	30
Education	Post graduate	20
	Graduate	21
Age	age > 35	10
	age 25- age 35	25
	age < 25	6
Experience	exp > 15	4
	exp 10 - exp 15	7
	exp 5 - exp 10	17
	exp < 5	13



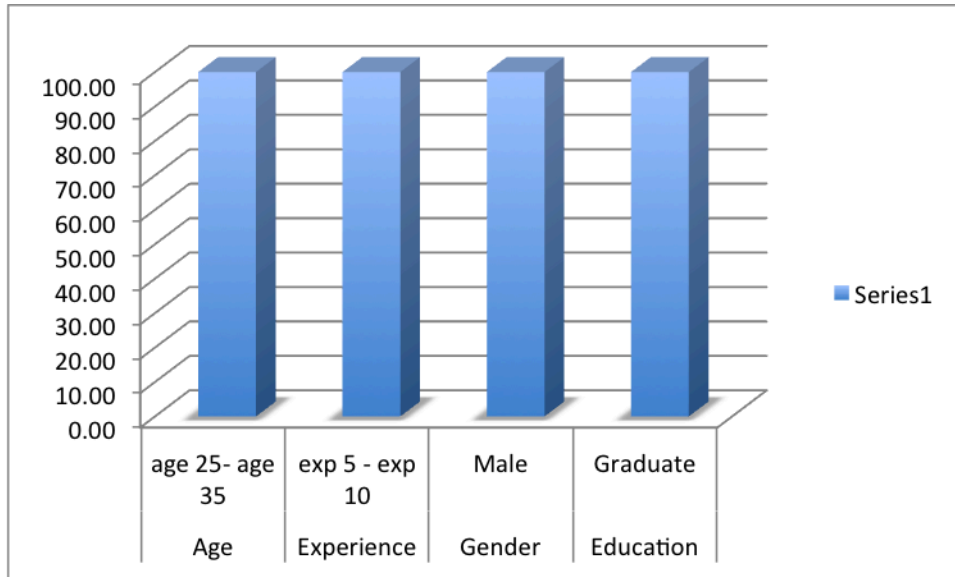
Avoiding

Dimension	Avoiding	# of People
Gender	Female	1
	Male	7
Education	Post graduate	2
	Graduate	6
Age	age > 35	0
	age 25- age 35	4
	age < 25	4
Experience	exp > 15	0
	exp 10 - exp 15	0
	exp 5 - exp 10	3
	exp < 5	5



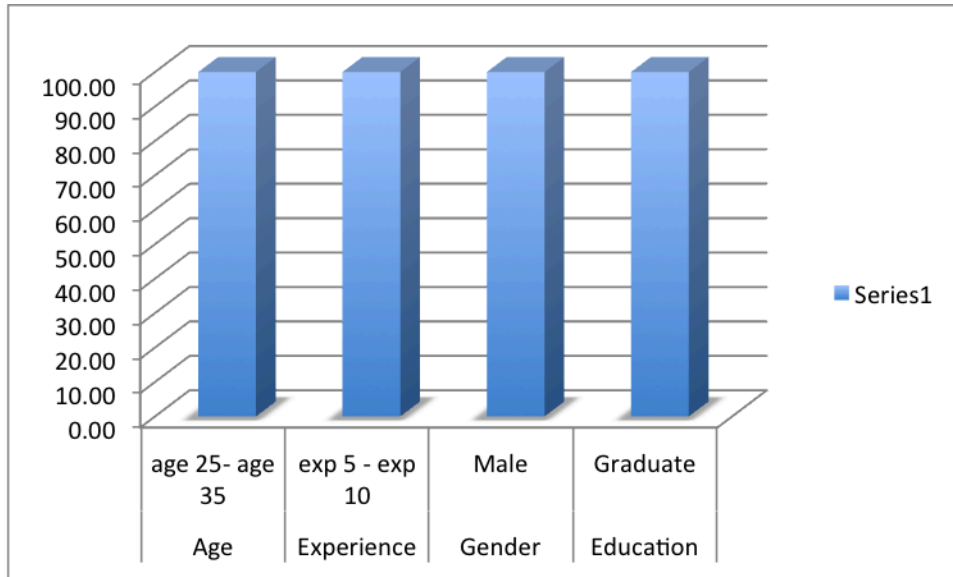
Accommodating

Dimension	Accommodating	# of people
Age	age 25- age 35	3
Experience	exp 5 - exp 10	3
Gender	Male	3
Education	Graduate	3



Competing

Dimension	Accommodatin	
	g	# of people
Age	age 25- age 35	2
Experience	exp 5 - exp 10	2
Gender	Male	2
Education	Graduate	2



Conclusion

Information technology industry where the survey was conducted has wonderful set of people who considers Collaboration as their primary conflict resolving style.

- The success of an organization can be directly correlated to the people's conflict resolving style.
- As an organization, train the people to collaborate to become successful!

References

<http://www.etu.org.za/toolbox/docs/building/conflict.html>

US Online Training course for Conflict Management, Developed by United States Institute of Peace (<http://www.usip.org>)

Appendix A: Instrument used

Instrument used to collect the data: Understand Your Own Conflict Management Style

Instructions:

Imagine that you are in situations where you do not agree with another person and try to respond to the following with that orientation.

Below, you will find several pairs of statements describing possible behavioral responses to situations. For each pair, circle the 'A' or the 'B' statement, which is most characteristic of your own behavior. In some cases neither the 'A' nor the 'B' statements would be representative of your

behavior; even so, try to select that which comes closest to what you may be liked to do.

The responses, which you circle, will offer you a good understanding of your conflict-handling style.

Statement 1

- A. I frequently decide that I should not bother about the differences in our viewpoints.
- B. I try to get my way.

Statement 2

- A. I try not to hurt the other's feelings so that our relationship can be maintained.
- B. I do all that is necessary to avoid tensions.

Statement 3

- A. I get all the issues out in the open and discuss them.
- B. I try to postpone issues till I have had time to think.

Statement 4

- A. I try to seek a solution, which is neither totally what I want nor what the other person wants.
- B. I try to assert my viewpoint.

Statement 5

- A. Many times I let the other person take on the responsibility for solving problem situations.
- B. Instead of trying to negotiate the things on which I might disagree with another, I usually emphasize the aspects on which we both agree.

Statement 6

- A. I am very goal-oriented and pursue my own goals.
- B. I try to patch up so that our friendship is not spoilt.

Statement 7

- A. I establish a middle ground.
- B. I do not think that I should worry about the differences.

Statement 8

- A. I take a middle ground.
- B. I insist on my points being heard.

Statement 9

- A. I firmly pursue my goals.
- B. I try to avoid frictions.

Statement 10

- A. I usually try to find a solution which is more compromising in nature.
- B. I usually try to handle all of the other party's as well as my own concerns.

Statement 11

- A. I try not to handle controversial issues.
- B. If it makes him happy, I let him have his say.

Statement 12

- A. I try not to create unpleasantness for myself.
- B. I try to win my own position.

Statement 13

- A. I try to be logical and show him the advantages of my position.
- B. I try to be sensitive to his wishes.

Statement 14

- A. To make the other person happy, I let him have his way.
- B. I will give in some, if he will give in some.

Statement 15

- A. I start working through the differences immediately.
- B. I try to see what is fair for both.

Statement 16

- A. I try to deal with both persons' wishes.
- B. I let him solve the problem.

Statement 17

- A. I usually search for a compromise solution.
- B. I usually let go of my own wishes so that the other person's needs are taken care of.

Statement 18

- A. I try to establish a middle ground.
- B. I try to satisfy both our wishes.

Statement 19

- A. I firmly stick to my point of view.
- B. I work out a solution with the other person.

Statement 20

- A. If the matter is that important to him, I let him have his way.
- B. I insist on a compromise.

Statement 21

- A. I usually get everyone's concerns out in the open.
- B. I usually try to give in and preserve our friendship.

Statement 22

- A. While negotiating, I take the other's feelings into consideration.
- B. I deal with the issue directly, placing all the cards on the table.

Statement 23

- A. I feel strongly about pursuing my goals.
- B. I feel compromise solutions are the best.

Statement 24

- A. I take time to think over the issue before starting to discuss it.
- B. I give in some to gain some.

Statement 25

- A. I would rather not hurt the other's feelings.
- B. I jointly work out the problem with the other person.

Statement 26

- A. I try not hurt the other's feelings.
- B. I convince the other of the logic of my statement.

Statement 27

- A. I express my ideas and ask for his.
- B. I try to convince him of the benefits of my ideas.

Statement 28.

- A. I firmly pursue my goals.
- B. I try to get all the issues out on the table.

Statement 29

- A. I generally avoid controversial situations.
- B. I pursue a policy of give and take.

Statement 30

- A. I invariably work with the other person's help to come up with a solution.
- B. I try my best to do whatever is necessary to avoid tensions.

Personal information

Name:

Gender:

Age:

Occupation:

Experience (number of years):

Qualification:

Appendix B: Results

Following tables describes the results of the Conflict Management Style survey. For tabular reasons, identified the columns by alphabets as below.

- A. Competing
- B. Collaborating
- C. Compromising
- D. Avoiding
- E. Accommodating

No	A	B	C	D	E	Age	Exp	Gender	Occupation	Qualification
1	2	10	9	5	4	33	7	M	QE	UG
2	4	11	8	3	4	33	9	F	QE	UG
3	5	6	7	7	5	28	6	M	QE	UG
4	3	9	9	8	1	30	7	F	QE	UG
5	7	8	8	2	5	21	0	F	SE	PG
6	5	9	10	5	1	32	7	M	SE	PG
7	4	10	4	8	4	29	7	M	QE	PG
8	5	8	5	6	6	23	1	M	SE	UG
9	7	8	7	5	3	38	15	M	Manager	PG
10	8	8	5	5	4	28	6	M	SE	UG
11	6	10	5	5	4	38	15	M	SE	UG
12	2	12	6	4	6	30	7	F	SE	UG
13	3	6	6	8	7	28	7	M	SE	UG
14	6	11	6	4	3	30	8	M	SE	UG
15	8	5	6	4	7	28	4	M	SE	UG

16	6	9	6	3	6	32	8	F	SE	UG
17	6	11	7	2	4	30	9	F	SE	UG
18	8	8	5	4	5	31	7	M	SE	UG
19	7	12	1	7	3	40	17	M	QE	PG
20	8	5	7	5	1	31	7	M	SERVICE	UG
21	7	10	4	7	2	32	10	M	Manager	UG
22	1	7	5	9	8	30	7	M	SERVICE	UG
23	5	6	9	4	6	23	1	F	SE	UG
24	5	8	5	9	3	28	7	M	SE	PG
25	7	5	6	5	7	32	6	M	SE	PG
26	1	9	8	4	8	29	7	M	SE	UG
27	9	8	4	6	3	24	3	M	SE	PG
28	9	10	4	4	3	33	12	M	SE	PG
29	3	9	4	8	6	29	8	M	SE	PG
30	4	8	7	6	5	33	8	M	Manager	PG
31	3	11	9	4	3	36	13	M	Manager	UG
32	5	4	8	7	6	29	9	M	SE	UG
33	8	8	2	8	4	40	15	M	SE	PG
34	10	5	5	6	4	23	1	M	SE	PG
35	2	5	7	9	7	31	7	M	SERVICE	UG
36	2	8	9	5	6	31	7	M	SE	UG
37	4	8	6	6	5	35	10	M	SE	UG
38	8	7	9	4	2	24	3	M	SERVICE	UG
39	10	8	5	2	5	35	10	M	Manager	PG
40	4	8	8	8	2	35	13	F	Manager	UG
41	5	11	3	7	4	25	4	M	SE	UG
42	4	7	7	6	6	28	7	M	SE	PG

43	4	7	10	3	6	34	12	M	SE	UG
44	8	8	3	4	7	28	5	M	SE	PG
45	6	8	5	4	7	43	19	M	SE	PG
46	3	9	6	5	7	25	3	F	SE	UG
47	6	7	3	8	6	35	13	M	SERVICE	PG
48	7	10	5	5	3	40	17	F	Manager	PG
49	8	7	8	4	3	23	1	M	SE	UG
50	8	11	5	4	2	34	11	M	SE	PG
51	6	9	7	6	2	37	13	M	SE	PG
52	7	10	7	2	4	24	3	F	SE	PG
53	2	8	9	5	6	28	6	M	SERVICE	PG
54	4	9	7	4	6	24	1	M	SE	PG
55	4	9	9	2	6	31	15	M	SERVICE	UG
56	3	10	8	4	5	35	15	M	SERVICE	PG
57	5	8	4	5	8	30	7	M	SE	UG
58	3	8	8	6	5	31	7	F	SE	UG
59	2	6	5	7	10	28	3	M	SE	PG
60	4	7	7	6	6	28	6	M	SE	PG
61	6	6	8	4	6	34	8	M	SE	UG
62	6	9	9	5	1	40	17	M	Manager	PG
63	7	10	5	5	3	36	15	M	SE	PG
Total	33	52	39	33	29					
I	5	2	9	2	7					